KRANENBURG POWER ADVISORS

Banked Fires

US coal retirements have stalled, and plants owners keep run harder than those held by order

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DECISION BRIEF

US Power and Utilities

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KPA CALLS

Each call carries a likelihood from the KPA scale, the date it resolves, and the record that decides it. KPA will score every call in a public scorecard.

- **Less than 1.5 gigawatts (GW) of US coal capacity retires in 2026, by the Energy Information Administration's (EIA) count.** Very likely (85%). Basis: none had retired by the end of September; of the 3.6 GW still dated for November and December, 2.6 GW is under federal orders that have been renewed every time they came due. Resolves February 2027, on EIA's Form 860M for December 2026.
- **At least half of the 6.2 GW of coal EIA lists to retire in 2027 is still in operation at the end of 2027.** Likely (60%). Basis: 27% of the coal listed for 2025 retired that year, and none of 2026's had by September; TVA's board has already voted to keep 0.7 GW of the 2027 group. Against that, Illinois law phases out the state's 2.9 GW share by 2030. Resolves February 2028, on EIA's Form 860M for December 2027.
- **J.H. Campbell is still listed as operating in EIA's inventory for March 2027.** Very likely (85%). Basis: DOE has renewed the plant's order five times since May 2025, and the one court ruling so far vacated an order that had already expired. Resolves May 2027, on EIA's Form 860M for March 2027.

WHAT WOULD CHANGE THIS VIEW

- A court ruling that sets aside an emergency order while it is in force.
- PJM or MISO capacity prices falling to half their current levels or less.
- Owners of the 2027 group outside TVA, starting with Vistra in Illinois, confirming their dates in EIA's monthly inventory through mid-2027.

INDEPENDENCE

KPA is self-funded and has no sponsors or clients. This brief was researched and drafted with AI assistance; every figure traces to a listed source, and KPA's own calculations are reproduced in code from EIA's public files. This is version 1.0. Corrections are dated and listed with each version, and published numbers are never changed silently.

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Banked Fires

US coal retirements have stalled, and plants owners keep run harder than those held by order

KEY IMPLICATIONS

On 14 November, the sixth federal emergency order keeping the J.H. Campbell coal plant in Michigan open expires; the plant was due to close in May 2025. In times past, a retirement date in the government's generator inventory was close to a promise: in 2016–24, 88% of the coal capacity listed a year ahead retired in the year listed. Yet the conveyor has stopped. In 2025, 27% did, and none of the 6.4 gigawatts (GW) listed for 2026 had retired by the end of September. KPA analysis shows who is holding the plants, and which ones run. Orders hold 3.7 GW of the 8.1 GW of delayed coal, and those units ran at 22% of capacity this year. Owners and grid contracts kept the other 4.4 GW, and those ran at 38%. The question is less whether the courts end the orders than whether owners still want to retire the 18 GW scheduled for 2027–28.

- **The retirement schedule has stopped working as a forecast.** Coal retirements fell from an average of 9.8 GW a year in 2015–24 to 2.7 GW in 2025, and to none in the first nine months of 2026. Owners have moved 2.8 GW of the coal listed for 2026 past the end of the year.
- **Plants held by federal order run far less than plants owners kept.** The ordered units ran at 22% of capacity in January–August 2026, down from 49% in the same months of 2022–24; one produced nothing. Units their owners chose to keep ran at 38%, against 47% for the US coal fleet. Net of market revenue, Campbell has cost about $460 per megawatt-day, 1.4 times the cap at which PJM's latest capacity auction cleared.
- **The coal scheduled for 2027–28 runs harder than the coal already kept.** EIA lists 18.3 GW to retire in 2027–28, 11% of the fleet, and none of it is under an order. Those units ran at 42% this year, and TVA has already voted to keep 1.9 GW of them. Of the rest, the 2016–24 rate would retire about 14 GW; 2025's, about 4 GW.

—November 2026

WHAT IS NEW IN THIS BRIEF

KPA searched for prior publication of each finding before release. These results were not found in that search; everything else is credited to its source.

- Coal units kept open by federal orders ran at 22% of capacity in January–August 2026, down from 49% in the same months of 2022–24; units their owners kept ran at 38%, up from 34%; the US fleet ran at 47%.
- In 2016–24, 88% of the coal capacity listed in EIA's December inventory to retire the next year retired in that year (73–100% by year), and 97% has retired since.
- Pooled across 2025 and 2026, federal orders hold 46% of the 8.1 GW of coal whose retirement date passed or moved past 2026; owners and grid contracts hold 54%.
- The 18.3 GW of coal EIA lists for 2027–28 ran at 42% of capacity in January–August 2026, and 8.3 GW of it ran at or above the fleet average.
- Net of market revenue, keeping Campbell has cost about $460 per megawatt-day, 1.4 times PJM's capped capacity price and about twice MISO's annualized price for 2025–26.

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Banked Fires: US coal retirements have stalled, and plants owners keep run harder than those held by order

Liam Kranenburg[1]

The retirement schedule has stopped working as a forecast

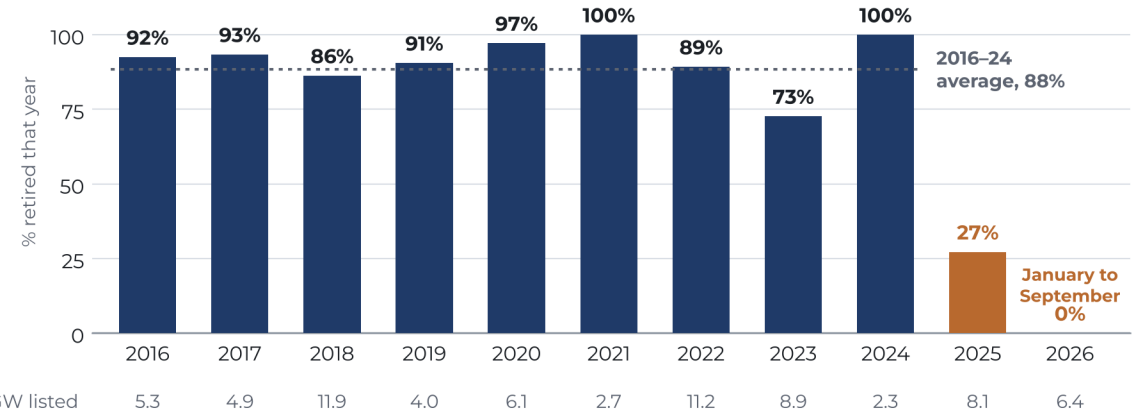
Every month, the owners of US power plants tell the Energy Information Administration (EIA) when each generator is due to retire, and EIA publishes the dates in its monthly inventory, Form EIA-860M. For a decade, that list was a dependable forecast for coal. KPA traced every coal unit in EIA's December inventories for 2015 to 2023 to its status in September 2026. Of the 57.4 gigawatts (GW) listed to retire in the following year, 88% retired in the year listed, and 97% has retired since (see Figure 1). Even in the weakest year, 2023, 73% went on time.[2]

The dates matter beyond the plants. Grid operators use them to judge how much capacity they will have; utilities use them to size what they build or buy; developers of new plants read them as a signal of demand. A list that is right nine times in 10 can be planned around. A list that is right one time in four cannot, and every buyer of capacity has to guess instead which old units will still be there.

FIGURE 1

Coal listed to retire next year used to retire; since 2025, most has not

Share of US coal capacity listed in each December EIA inventory to retire the following year that retired in that year; GW listed below each bar (2026: January to September)



Source: KPA analysis of EIA Form 860M data. © KPA

1. *Kranenburg Power Advisors. Researched and drafted with AI assistance. All calculations in this brief use the public figures listed under Sources.*

2. *KPA matched generators by plant and generator ID across EIA-860M inventories, using September 2026 net summer capacity. Coal covers EIA energy codes BIT, SUB, LIG, RC, WC and SGC. For 2021, 0.67 GW whose generator ID no longer appears is excluded; with it, the 2016–24 share is 87%.*

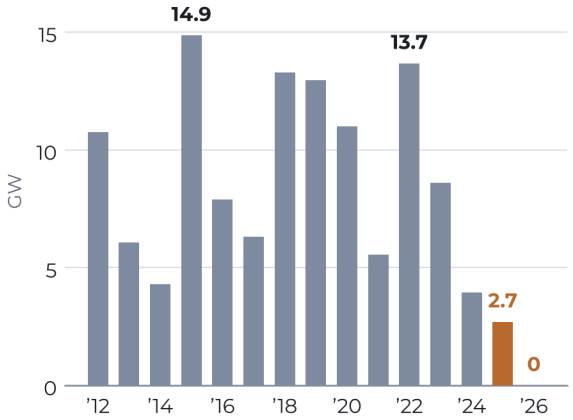
Then the schedule stopped. Of the 8.1 GW listed in December 2024 to retire in 2025, 2.2 GW did: the two units at Intermountain in Utah and one at Indian River in Delaware. EIA reported the shortfall in February, counting 2.6 GW of coal retired against 8.0 GW planned. The 2026 list has fared worse. None of the 6.4 GW listed in December 2025 had retired by the end of September, and EIA's September inventory records no coal retirement of any kind this year.[3] In 2015–24, the United States retired an average of 9.8 GW of coal a year. In 2025, it retired 2.7 GW, the least since 2010, though only just below 2011 (see Figure 2).

The units have not slipped by a few weeks. Owners have moved 2.8 GW of the 2026 list past the end of the year. The board of the Tennessee Valley Authority (TVA) voted in February to keep its Cumberland and Kingston plants running, citing load growth of about 2% a year. The board set no new dates, but EIA's September inventory now lists December 2034 for Cumberland unit 2 and three Kingston units, 1.7 GW.

FIGURE 2

US coal retirements fell to 2.7 GW in 2025, and none so far in 2026

US coal capacity retired by year, GW, 2012 to September 2026



Source: KPA analysis of EIA Form 860M data. © KPA

Wisconsin Electric moved two South Oak Creek units to the end of 2027, their third delay, as a bridge to new plants due that year. The Grand River Dam Authority shelved the retirement of a unit of 479 megawatts (MW) in Oklahoma after a $28.5 million federal grant toward upgrades. Gas and oil steam units show the same break from a lower base: 56% of their listed capacity retired on time in 2016–24, and 27% in 2025.

Some of this capacity will retire late rather than never. Of the coal that missed its date in 2023, nearly half has retired since, and 3.6 GW of coal is still dated for November or December 2026. Yet 2.6 GW of that remaining capacity is under federal emergency orders, which the Department of Energy (DOE) has renewed each time they came due. Colorado's regulators are weighing a settlement that would keep another unit, Comanche 2, running to March 2028. The conveyor that for a decade delivered nine in 10 scheduled gigawatts on time has stopped, and the inventory no longer says when it will restart.

3. *EIA, Today in Energy, 23 February 2026; EIA's 2.6 GW includes units retired without having been listed a year ahead. The analyst MV2 (Munim, Inc.) reported earlier, on 16 and 29 October 2026, that none of the 2026 list had retired, and put 2025's on-time share at 26% of planned capacity; KPA's 27% uses September 2026 net summer capacity. KPA's 2.7 GW for all of 2025 counts every coal generator that EIA's September 2026 inventory shows as retired that year.*

Plants held by federal order run far less than plants owners kept

Two hands hold the delayed coal. Since May 2025, DOE has used section 202(c) of the Federal Power Act to order six coal plants to stay available past their planned retirement, in orders that run 90 days at a time. Campbell came first. Centralia in Washington, Schahfer and Culley in Indiana, and Craig in Colorado followed in December 2025, and Stanton in Florida in June 2026.

KPA matched every delayed unit to DOE's orders and its owner's filings. Of the 8.1 GW of coal whose 2025 or 2026 date has passed or moved past 2026, the orders cover 3.7 GW, or 46%. Owners, or their contracts with grid operators, kept the other 4.4 GW.[4] The largest is Brandon Shores in Maryland, 1.3 GW that Talen Energy runs under a reliability-must-run contract with the PJM grid operator until May 2029, for $312 per megawatt-day (MW-day) plus fuel.

The split fits DOE's own account. In January, DOE said that "more than 17 gigawatts" of coal generation had been saved in 2025, without naming the plants. Its orders that year covered about 3.7 GW, even on DOE's larger unit ratings, and Energy Secretary Chris Wright has said that only some of the total came from emergency orders. Whatever the full count, most of the coal that stayed open did so because its owner, its regulator or its grid operator wanted it to.

The two groups do not run alike. KPA analysis of EIA's generator-level output data through August shows that the units held by orders ran at 22% of their capacity in January–August 2026, down from 49% in the same months of 2022–24 (see Figure 3). Units kept by their owners ran at 38%, up from 34%. The US coal fleet ran at 47%. The gap is not universal: Campbell ran at 40% and Stanton at 43%, above the owner-kept average.[5]

Centralia unit 2 produced no power at all; TransAlta, its owner, has said the region is flush with hydropower, and it plans to convert the unit to gas for a contract that starts in late 2028. Schahfer unit 18 has been out since a rotor blade failed in July 2025, and unit 17 was taken down for repairs in March, with a return expected in October. Craig unit 1 ran only when the regional grid operator called on it, in April and July. Campbell and Stanton produced 91% of the ordered units' output.

The orders ask for availability, not output. Each directs the owner to keep the unit ready and to run it on economic dispatch, when the grid operator finds it cheaper than the alternatives. Availability is not cheap. Consumers Energy reports that Campbell

4. *EIA split 2025's delays into orders and operator decisions in April 2026, and MV2 split the 2026 list in October. Taken one year at a time, orders hold the larger share of 2025's delays and owners of 2026's; pooled, owners hold more. KPA counts Stanton 1, whose owner had already moved its date to May 2026 when the order came, with the orders.*

5. *Capacity factor = net generation ÷ (net summer capacity × hours), January–August 2026, from EIA-923 generator data released 22 October 2026; months of negative net generation, which reflect station use while idle, count as zero. The 2022–24 comparison uses the same months. The fleet figure is EIA's, from Electric Power Monthly Table 6.07.A. Falling output at the ordered plants was reported earlier by Utility Dive (23 June 2026), Argus (30 March 2026) and MV2 (19 October 2026); the comparison with owner-kept units and the fleet is KPA's. MV2 also noted that the orders require availability, not generation.*

has cost $303 million through September, net of $344 million in market revenue, or about $611,000 a day. By KPA's calculation, that is about $460 per MW-day of the plant's capacity.[6]

Campbell's $460 is 1.4 times the $325 cap at which PJM's latest capacity auction cleared, and about twice MISO's annualized capacity price for 2025–26, when most of the cost was incurred; for 2026–27, it is 3.6 to 4 times. For Schahfer, the Northern Indiana Public Service Company (NIPSCO) has asked to recover $38.0 million, net, for the first quarter of 2026, when one derated unit ran for two months: about $118 for each megawatt-hour it produced. In EIA's inventory, every one of these units is listed as operating. At the fleet's rate of use, the ordered units' 2026 output could have come from 1.7 GW of coal.

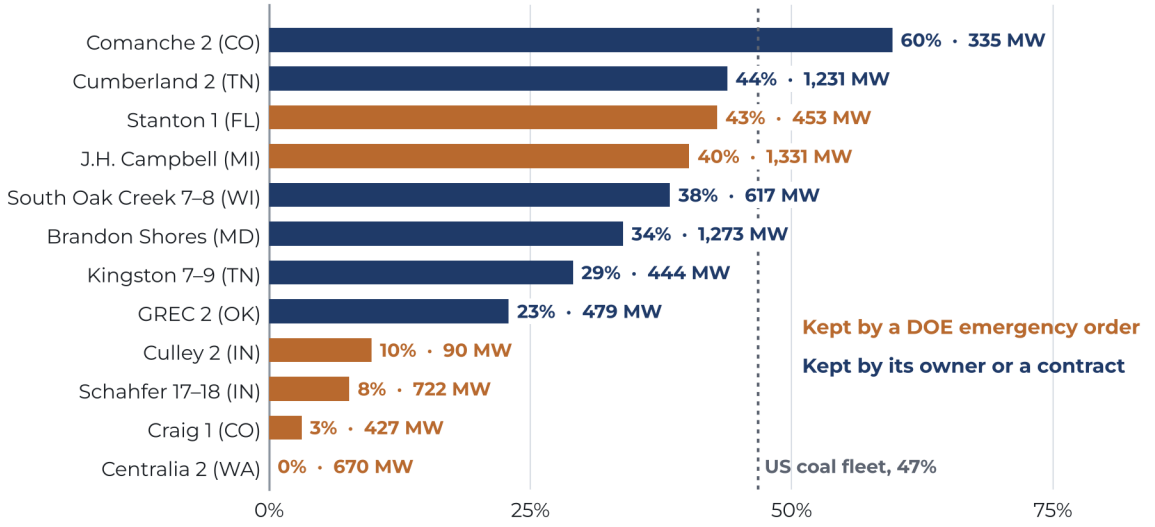
Availability has a value that averages hide. DOE says Campbell ran above 650 MW every day during Winter Storm Fern in late January, and in January as a whole Campbell ran at 59% of capacity, slightly above the fleet's 58%. A memo by Energy Ventures Analysis, posted by the coal industry group America's Power, estimated that the plant's market revenue likely exceeded its costs in its first five weeks under order; Consumers later put that order's net cost at $42 million.

Yet the units under orders in January, Stanton aside, ran at 32% of capacity that month, and Centralia and Craig produced nothing; Craig was under repair until 20 January. The owner-kept units ran at 44%. A plant held as insurance should run hardest when the grid is tightest; most of these did not.

FIGURE 3

Plants owners kept are running; several kept by order are not

Capacity factor, January–August 2026, of US coal units whose planned 2025 or 2026 retirement has passed or moved past 2026, by who kept them



Source: KPA analysis of EIA-923 and EIA Form 860M data; fleet from EIA Electric Power Monthly. © KPA

6. *KPA calculation: $303 million ÷ (1,331 MW × 496 days, 23 May 2025 to 30 September 2026) = $459 per MW-day. On DOE's larger 1,560 MW rating, $392. Consumers Energy, Form 10-Q, 27 October 2026. The Federal Energy Regulatory Commission (FERC) has agreed to spread Campbell's costs across the MISO North and Central zones.*

The coal scheduled for 2027–28 runs harder than the coal already kept

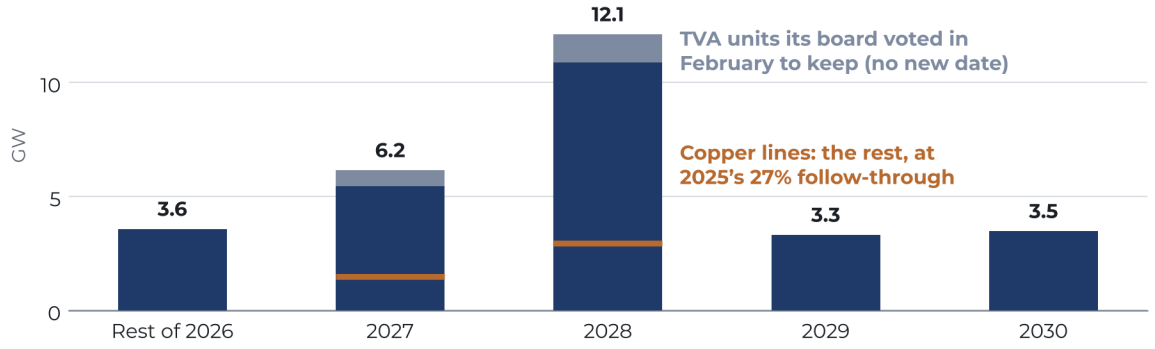
The orders are now in court. On 11 September, the federal appeals court in Washington, D.C., vacated DOE's first Campbell order, finding that section 202(c) is a narrow, last-resort backstop and that there was no emergency within its meaning. DOE has asked for a rehearing and has kept renewing its other orders. Whatever the courts decide, the orders reach only part of the schedule. They cover 2.6 GW of the coal still dated for 2026 and none of the 18.3 GW that EIA lists for 2027–28, which is 11% of the 167.8 GW US coal fleet (see Figure 4).

That schedule belongs to the owners, and the plants on it are working. KPA analysis of EIA's output data shows the 2027–28 group ran at 42% of its capacity in January–August 2026, above the 38% of the units owners have already chosen to keep. Of the 18.3 GW, 8.3 GW ran at or above the fleet average, among them Rockport unit 1 in Indiana, Monroe in Michigan, Baldwin in Illinois and Cardinal unit 3 in Ohio. TVA's board has already voted to keep 1.9 GW of the group, Kingston units 1–6 and Cumberland unit 1, though EIA still lists their old dates.[7] Their owners will weigh the dates against capacity prices that have risen sharply. PJM's auction for 2028–29 cleared at its $325 cap and fell short of its reliability requirement for the second year running. MISO's summer price for 2026–27 was $424 per MW-day in its northern and central zones, down from $667 a year earlier.

FIGURE 4

Scheduled coal retirements peak at 12.1 GW in 2028

Operating US coal capacity by planned retirement year, GW; TVA units its board voted to keep shown in grey; copper lines show the rest of 2027–28 at 2025's 27% follow-through



Source: KPA analysis of EIA Form 860M, September 2026. © KPA

Prices are not the only lever, and they do not reach every plant. Much of the 2028 group belongs to regulated utilities, whose retirement plans pass through state commissions and whose customers pay for a unit kept open whether or not it runs. TVA sells no capacity into a market at all; its board kept its coal for load growth. The signal

7. *Rockport's output is reported under two generator IDs per unit, which KPA sums. Of the 2027–28 group, 1.6 GW ran below 10%: Merrimack in New Hampshire, Kincaid unit 1 in Illinois, Daniel unit 1 in Mississippi and Kingston unit 5.*

from MISO is also weaker than a year ago: its summer price fell by more than a third. Still, the owners who have kept coal so far have kept units they use, and the 2027–28 group is used harder still.

The strongest case for the schedule holding is in Illinois. The state's 2021 climate law phases out private coal generation by 2030, and Vistra said in 2021 that its Illinois coal plants would retire no later than 2027. Its Baldwin, Kincaid and Newton units make up 2.9 GW of the 2027 group, and they ran at 40% this year. Elsewhere, the record points the other way. Setting aside the TVA units, 16.3 GW remains, and three futures span the range. If 2027–28 follows 2016–24, about 14.4 GW retires. If it follows 2025, about 4.4 GW retires. If it follows 2026 to date, almost none does.

A banked fire is one a stoker covers with ash to keep it smoldering, ready to be raised. The orders have banked several plants that their owners were letting go cold, and some sit idle under the ash. The owners, meanwhile, keep stoking the plants they want, because those plants are being used. If owners treat the rest of the 2027–28 schedule as they treated 2025's, retiring about a quarter of it, the United States will enter 2029 with about 14 GW more coal than its own schedule assumes. That is about as much as it retired in 2022, its largest year since 2015.

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Sources

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2. EIA, "Retirement delays of U.S. electric generating capacity may continue in 2026," *Today in Energy*, 23 February 2026; EIA, *Today in Energy*, 13 April 2026 (2025 delays by DOE order and operator decision).
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4. J. Schulz, "We Energies delays retirement of Oak Creek coal units to 2027 again," WPR, 6 April 2026.
5. P. Monies, Oklahoma Watch via KGOU, 11 June 2026 (Grand River Dam Authority, GREC unit 2).
6. Colorado Public Utilities Commission, fact sheet on Comanche unit 2 retirement extension, December 2025; A. Best, KUNC, 7 November 2026 (settlement through March 2028).
7. US Department of Energy (DOE), Office of Cybersecurity, Energy Security and Emergency Response, "2025 DOE 202(c) Orders" and "2026 DOE 202(c) Orders" (order numbers, dates and terms); D. Dwyer, "Emergency order for West Michigan coal plant set to expire again," Michigan Public, 9 November 2026.
8. Talen Energy, news releases of 27 January 2025 (reliability-must-run settlement for Brandon Shores and Wagner) and 1 May 2025 (FERC approval).
9. EIA, Form EIA-923, generator data, 2021–25 final releases and 2026 monthly release of 22 October 2026 (January–August); EIA, *Electric Power Monthly*, Table 6.07.A (coal capacity factors).
10. E. Howland, *Utility Dive*: 4 March 2026 (TransAlta, Centralia gas conversion), 23 June 2026 (output of plants under orders) and 2 October 2026 (FERC on Centralia cost recovery); Argus, 30 March 2026.
11. NIPSCO, transmittal letter to FERC on section 202(c) cost recovery, 4 August 2026 (Schahfer outages, first-quarter 2026 costs); L. Bonilla Muñiz, *Indiana Capital Chronicle*, 7 August 2026; J. St. John, *Canary Media*, 9 January 2026; M. Jaffe, *Colorado Sun*, 21 July 2026 (Craig unit 1).
12. CMS Energy and Consumers Energy, Form 10-Q for the third quarter of 2026, 27 October 2026 (Campbell compliance costs and MISO revenue; FERC cost allocation).
13. PJM Interconnection, 2028/2029 Base Residual Auction results, 14 July 2026; E. Howland, *Utility Dive*, 29 April 2026 (MISO 2026–27 Planning Resource Auction).
14. DOE, "Fact sheet: Energy Department prevented blackouts and saved American lives during winter storms," 6 February 2026 (Campbell output during Winter Storm Fern, DOE's own figures); Energy Ventures Analysis, Campbell analysis memo, 5 September 2025, posted by America's Power; CMS Energy and Consumers Energy, Form 10-Q, 27 October 2026 (net cost of the first order).
15. *Michigan v. U.S. Department of Energy*, No. 25-1159 (D.C. Cir. 11 September 2026); P. Ciampoli, APPA *Public Power*, 30 October 2026 (DOE rehearing petition).
16. State of Illinois, Climate and Equitable Jobs Act (2021), summary at ev.illinois.gov; Vistra, statement of 15 September 2021 (Illinois coal retirements no later than 2027).
17. KPA calculations (Figures 1–4, follow-through rates, the split of delayed coal by who kept it, capacity factors, the 2027–28 group and the cost per MW-day) are reproducible from the data files and code published with this brief.
18. Prior work this brief builds on: MV2 (Munim, Inc.), posts on dev.to of 16, 18, 19 and 29 October 2026 and the open repository *eia860m-slip* (2025 on-time share, no 2026 coal retirements, the 2026 split by order and owner, output of ordered plants, retirement dates that track order expiry); EIA, *Today in Energy*, 13 April 2026 (2025 split); E. Howland, *Utility Dive*, 23 June 2026, and Argus, 30 March 2026 (output of ordered plants); DeSmog, 12 December 2025 (list of delayed coal plants). MV2's work is an AI-assisted, self-published analysis and is credited here as prior work only.